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Travel from Pakistan to UAE in a ferry soon

DUBAI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Senior Assistant Editor

Passengers will soon be able to travel from Pakistan to Gulf countries and Iran using the affordable ferry service.

Pakistan has approved its first international ferry service, opening new sea routes to Iran and Gulf countries, including the UAE.

The Ministry of Maritime Affairs issued the first ferry service licence to UK-based operator Sea Keeper, paving the way for modern passenger ferries to begin operations from Karachi and Gwadar.

With Pakistan's air and road infrastructure under pressure, the introduction of ferry services offers a cost-effective, efficient, and sustainable alternative for international travel and trade. Beyond easing the current travel crisis, the initiative is expected to revive maritime activity, open up tourism potential, and promote regional integration with Gulf countries.

'New history'

Federal Minister for Maritime Affairs Muhammad Junaid Anwar Chaudhry, who led the fast-track approval, said the service marks a "new history of maritime connectivity" for the region.

The new ferry route offers direct sea travel from Pakistan to Iran, with future expansions planned to other Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries including the UAE, Bahrain, and Oman.

UAE ship Khalifa arrives at Egypt port with Gaza aid

EIGHTH AID SHIP LOADED WITH 7,166 TONNES OF HUMANITARIAN ASSISTANCE

ABU DHABI

The eighth UAE aid ship, Khalifa, reached Al Arish Port in Egypt yesterday as part of Operation Chivalrous Knight 3, in preparation for delivering its cargo to the Gaza Strip, in continuation of the UAE's humanitarian support for the Palestinian people.

The ship was received by a delegation of representatives from humanitarian and charitable organisations, along with Ahmad Sari Al Mazrouei, Secretary-General of the Emirates Red Crescent (ERC), and Egyptian officials.

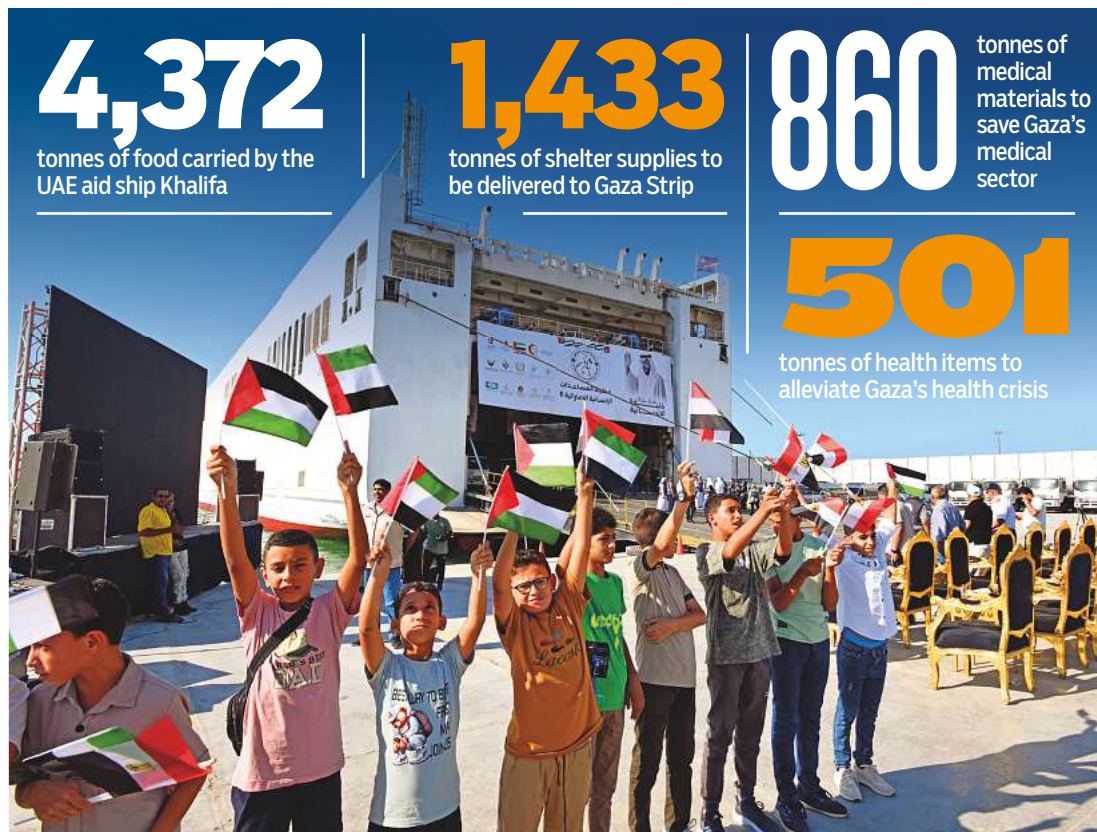
The arrival of the Khalifa aid ship underscores the UAE's steadfast commitment to delivering humanitarian and relief aid to the Palestinian people, especially amid the escalating humanitarian challenges in the Gaza Strip.

Departing from Khalifa Port in Abu Dhabi, the ship was loaded with 7,166 tonnes of humanitarian assistance, including food, medicines, medical supplies, relief items, dates and shelter materials, for the Palestinian people in the Gaza Strip.

Series of initiatives

Comprising 4,372 tonnes of food, 1,433 tonnes of shelter supplies, 860 tonnes of medical materials, and 501 tonnes of health items, the shipment brings the overall aid dispatched to the Gaza Strip to more than 80,000 tonnes.

As part of a continuous series of initiatives, the UAE dispatched this ship to deliver urgent aid to the Palestinian people, reaffirm-



The shipment delivered by the eighth UAE aid ship, Khalifa, brings the overall aid dispatched to the Gaza Strip to more than 80,000 tonnes.

ing its enduring humanitarian stance in supporting just causes and reducing the impact of crises in the region.

Earlier on Monday, the UAE carried out the 62nd airdrop of aid under the Birds of Goodness initiative, part of Operation Chivalrous Knight 3. The operation is being conducted in collaboration with Jordan, with the participation of France, Germany, Belgium and Canada.

These operations aim to de-

liver urgent humanitarian aid to areas inaccessible by land due to the prevailing security situation. The airdrop included a range of essential food items and emergency relief supplies.

3,829 tonnes of aid by air

With Monday's mission, the total volume of aid delivered by air has now surpassed 3,829 tonnes, directed towards supporting the most affected and vulnerable communities in Gaza.

In parallel, the UAE has delivered 40 trucks loaded with food aid into the Gaza Strip, as part of its ongoing efforts to strengthen humanitarian support and meet the essential needs of the population.

These initiatives reaffirm the UAE's steadfast commitment to humanitarian principles and its enduring approach of standing with fraternal nations in times of crisis and emergency.

— WAM
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Too many strong quakes in last 30 days: Should you be worried?

People are losing sleep over the reported 396 big earthquakes

MANILA

BY JAY HILOTIN
Senior Assistant Editor

Social media is shaking over "too many earthquakes" this month. But is it really unusual?

People are losing sleep over the reported 396 earthquakes of Magnitude 5.0 or greater (M5+) recorded worldwide in the past 30 days. "Is the Earth breaking up with us?" one user joked.

But before we all start prepping bunkers and learning Morse code, let's look at what the data actually says. According to the United States Geological Survey (USGS), the planet experiences an average of 1,300 to 1,500 magnitude 5+ earthquakes per year.

That breaks down to about 110 to 125 per month. So yes — 396 in 30 days is notably high-

er than normal. But here's the twist: this isn't the first time this has happened.

Seismologists point out that global earthquake activity is clustered, not evenly spaced out. You can have a relatively quiet month followed by an explosive one — and it's still within normal geophysical variation.

For example, in April 2015, following the Nepal quake, aftershocks and regional activity pushed the global count over 400 for that month. Ditto for December 2004, post the Sumatra quake and tsunami.

Plus, most of these recent quakes have happened along tectonically active zones like the Pacific "Ring of Fire" — not in totally random places. So, should we worry? Not yet, say experts. The Earth's just doing its thing. Maybe a bit louder than usual — but still within the bounds of geophysical normal.

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